Then we went home. We spent Labor Day (September 1) at the Bronx Zoo, with Roy Machlowitz. It was my first visit there and the first time I ever saw such animals as gibbons, hummingbirds, and a panda. The duck-bill platypus was the great attraction of the zoo at the time, but the building that housed them was closed by the time we got to it—so to this day I've never seen a platypus.

My mother's fifty-second birthday came on September 5, 1947, and when we visited her to commemorate the day, we found that she had discovered what everyone discovers when they undertake anything to do with building or renovation: The actual expense invariably outstrips the estimate. They had planned to spend $1,500 and it was costing $2,000.

I was uneasy about that, of course, since I felt that it was my duty as a son to offer to pick up the tab for anything over $1,500, but that was certainly not my duty as a tenant—and the incompatibility of the two roles bothered me.

The incompatibility became more acute when my parents became aware that we were planning to furnish the apartment rather skimpily, with a view to moving out eventually. After all, we couldn't possibly expect it to be our lifetime home—but that, apparently, was exactly what my parents thought it would be, or should be.

There were arguments between us on the matter (myself and my parents, that is, for Gertrude wisely did not interfere), and I was more than ever determined that though we would move in for the experience of space at last, we would move out when something better came along.

My attitude toward my mother's attempt to dictate our system of buying furniture was described as follows in my diary: "I was very, very peeved indeed because what the hell business is it of hers?"— which puts it in a nutshell.

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I had to look toward the future in other ways, too. I was certain that sometime in 1948 I would complete my research, get my degree, and be out in the cold world. It meant I would need a job, for nothing in my nine years' career as a professional writer gave me any cause to suppose that I could ever support myself with my typewriter.

Until now I had always postponed the evil day of job-hunting by